

WASHINGTON, D. C., TUESDAY, MARCH 10, 1942.

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Lusk's Figures Questioned at Wage Hearing

88 Pct. of Housing Built at 'B' Scale, He Asserts

Rufus S. Lusk, real estate statistician, was sharply cross-examined by union representatives at the Labor Department's prevailing wage hearing today after he had asserted that 88 per cent of all residential construction in Metropolitan Washington in 1941 was erected at open-shop rates.

The hearing is to determine wage rates to be paid here in the Government's huge war housing program. A portion of the evidence was heard last Tuesday. It was adjourned at that time until today to allow building trades union leaders and private builders opportunity to assemble additional evidence.

10 Per Cent by Government.

Mr. Lusk said that 23,625 residential family units were built last year in the metropolitan area. Of these, 2,364, or 10.1 per cent, were erected by various Government agencies and 89.9 per cent by private builders. Mr. Lusk said that 2 per cent of the private work was provided at the closed shop or "A" wage scale. Including public operations, most of which was built at the high union wage, about 12 per cent of all building was provided by closed shop contracts.

Stating that he had complete figures on all residential construction in Washington for the past seven years, Mr. Lusk said he was able to find only a few private jobs erected in the past year at the full union scale. He said that generally a more elaborate type of single-family residence.

Mr. Lusk added that he had a partial breakdown of wages paid by builders on 20 per cent of all the private residential work of 1941. He submitted the figures as a "sample" which showed the general private construction wage scale. Out of 996 common laborers employed on the projects, 15 per cent received 40 cents an hour, 48 per cent got 45 cents an hour and the remainder 50 and 55 cents. The union scale for laborers is 85 cents an hour.

Data on Carpenters. He also submitted data on 623 carpenters, of which 54 per cent were paid \$1 an hour and 15 per cent \$1.10 an hour. The remainder got varying rates, some lower and a few higher than the figures quoted. About 84 per cent of the bricklayers on the private jobs received \$1.37 an hour.

Statisticians presented figures tending to show that as labor and construction costs increased residential building was dropped after Mr. Lusk said that increased costs, principally raises in labor rates, brought building operations nearly to a halt in 1921. He said that home building costs rose 150 per cent from 1913 to 1921, largely due to increased wages of labor. When wages dropped after 1921, he said, building picked up. Since then most of the private builders have operated non-union shops, Mr. Lusk said.

Many Workers Available.

On the subject of availability of labor, Robert A. Morrison, division chief in charge of building trades at the District Employment Center, testified as to the number of building mechanics on his rolls in February. The list, he said, included both union and non-union workers, and he had no figures as to the number of common laborers available for work.

The number included 39 electricians, 161 bricklayers, 235 carpenters, 167 cement finishers, 115 plasterers, 17 pipefitters, 34 plumbers, 16 steamfitters and 8 asbestos workers. Mr. Morrison said that last month his office cleared more than 1,000 workers in all industrial classifications.

The testimony of Mr. Lusk was criticized by four union leaders, who took turns cross-examining him on many details in the questionnaire he had submitted regarding the construction projects.

John Locher, secretary of the Washington Building Trades Council, objected to the testimony of Mr. Lusk as having paid too much attention to the question of an open shop or a closed shop, but not on the question of prevailing wages.

Lusk Data Questioned. Taking up the questionnaire of a contractor whose name was not identified by the witnesses, Willy Arnsheim of the Laborers' District Council objected to a report which showed that there had been 668 houses in a project running over a period from 1938 to the present time on which it was reported that 30 carpenters had been paid at the rate of a dollar an hour.

Mr. Lusk said the report would be adjusted to indicate generally how many houses the carpenters worked on within the year 1941, which is the basis for the prevailing wage hearing.

At this point Frank Howard, of the Carpenters' District Council, pointed out that the union had recently furnished about 500 carpenters at a higher union wage on a big Government job to build 450 housing units within four months. He said it was questionable whether sufficient number of carpenters could be obtained at the lower wage rate of a dollar an hour to build big Government housing projects quickly.

Report to Be Asked. Clem F. Preller, an electrician union official, who is president of the Building Trades Council, insisted that one of the projects reported by Mr. Lusk certain electricians were hanging fixtures had received an hourly wage of \$1.80 instead of the figures of 75 cents and \$1 per hour reported in the questionnaire of the contractors.

After some argument between the labor and building representatives at the hearing over this point, it was agreed the builder would be asked to furnish the report on elec-

Maryland Shore Blackout Asked By Gen. Drum

By The Associated Press.

ANNAPOLIS, March 10.—A request for immediate blackouts or elimination of Maryland shore illumination was received by Gov. O'Connor today from Lt. Gen. H. A. Drum, 1st Army commander.

Gen. Drum said sinkings of coastwise shipping "through action of hostile submarines operating under the cover of darkness makes it imperative immediate steps be taken."

The Army officer based his request on the grounds that "any shore illumination serves to silhouette passing vessels to enemy observation."

Gov. O'Connor said State officials would take immediate action to "comply with Gen. Drum's request as quickly as possible."

The Governor asserted he has learned unofficially that the entire Atlantic coast soon will be permanently blacked out to reduce enemy attacks on merchant vessels.

D. C. May Evacuate Institutions Near Military Objectives

Emergency Care Will Be Provided For Inmates

Welfare Director Conrad Van Hynning will have for Commissioner Guy Mason within a week a report on plans to evacuate inmates of several District institutions near possible military objectives in the event of a bombing.

Mr. Van Hynning has been discussing the problem with the institutions and indicated yesterday that unless bombings here should be of a serious and devastating nature, the situation could probably be met by shifting of inmates temporarily from one institution to the other. If one institution was damaged, inmates could be absorbed elsewhere, he indicated.

Institutions Affected. In the event of "actually serious bombing" here, the welfare director said funds might be sought and approved for erection of temporary shelter in nearby Maryland or Virginia away from danger. He said the possibility of the evacuation using District-owned land at Muirkirk, Md., for such temporary shelter if, as a last resort, it should become necessary.

Institutions affected include the Home for Aged and Infirm and the Industrial Home for the Deaf and Blind, near the Naval Air Station at Blue Plains, near naval air and research installations in Anacostia; Industrial Home School for the Deaf on Wisconsin avenue near the Naval Observatory; the District Training School for Feeble-Minded near Fort Myer; the National Training School for Girls on MacArthur boulevard, near the Reservoir, and the Receiving Home near the Navy Yard.

Hospitals May Help Out. Mr. Van Hynning said in the case of the two industrial home schools and the National Training School for Girls, consideration was being given in regard to which inmates could be sent home in event of trouble and which would have to be provided for. In the case of the Home for the Aged, he indicated local hospitals and emergency medical establishments might have to provide for the hospital cases, while other able-bodied inmates might be placed in homes.

In cases where detention will be necessary, Mr. Van Hynning said some space might be found in the District Jail.

Col. Louis Johnson Heads U. S. Mission to India

By The Associated Press.

The United States Advisory Mission to India will be headed by Col. Louis Johnson, former Assistant Secretary of War, the State Department announced yesterday.

It has been estimated, according to a Federal Works spokesman, that \$1,000,000 would be needed for a complete blackout of Government buildings in the Washington area to permit normal night time operation but the \$1,000,000 included in the budget would not be available for Capital blackouts.

Provision already has been made for blacking out such strategic spots in Government buildings as communications centers, telephone switchboards, guard rooms, essential offices of the War, Navy and State Departments. Much of this construction, Mr. Snyder said, has been completed.

How soon and how much blacking out will be done other than turning off the lights was not indicated by the acting administrator. He said "certain protective measures cannot be made effective instantly, but all will be pushed with the utmost speed."

Present plans, he pointed out, call for installation of a signal system in buildings where they will be extinguished so all illumination could be terminated except that essential for safety, which would not be visible outside the building.

Mr. Snyder said he would seek special authority where necessary to prosecute the 100 per cent blackout.

57 Rookie Policemen To Join D. C. Force

A class of 57 rookie policemen will be distributed among the precincts Monday, following completion of a training school course.

The class will be replaced immediately by another group, as police officials strive to place on duty the full authorized strength of the force. The first District deficiency appropriation makes possible addition of 85 more privates, six sergeants and four lieutenants. Still to be filled are six other vacancies—three sergeants and three lieutenants.

Total strength of the department will be 1,711 when these positions are filled.

Plans Adopted To Black Out U. S. Buildings

391 Offices Under P. B. A. to Be Made Completely Dark

Federal buildings, previously conspicuous by their bright lights during Washington blackouts, will be as dark as the rest of the city in future blackouts, Acting Federal Works Administrator Baird Snyder said today.

The Public Buildings Administration, under Mr. Snyder, in effect has abandoned the simple "lights out" blackout policy Mr. Snyder previously contended was sufficient safeguard against the possibility of air raids.

Funds the P. B. A. was hesitant to release without assurances they would be paid back probably will be used in areas to be blacked out, the acting administrator said.

Order for Materials Placed.

Backing up Mr. Snyder's promise of action, the P. B. A. immediately placed an order for 30,000 yards of blackout material, as much as the entire amount bought previously for the "strategic" spots in Federal buildings. The order brings the amount spent for materials and labor to \$60,000, a P. B. A. spokesman disclosed.

The final cost, it was said, will not be determined until all Federal agencies have reported how many of their employees have to work at night. If materials for essential blacking out come to as much as \$250,000, as is expected in some quarters, the work will have to be let out on contract.

In the event that the P. B. A., which has jurisdiction over 391 Federal buildings as a part of the Federal Works Agency, had swung into line followed a conference between Mr. Snyder and James M. Landis, director of the Office of Civilian Defense, at which, according to Mr. Snyder, "full accord was reached on steps to be taken to insure complete and effective obscuration of illumination" in the 391 buildings.

Two Plans Suggested. The blackout, he said, would affect all Federal buildings under P. B. A., including those where work must continue during an air raid alarm. A survey, he announced, is now under way to determine what personnel must remain on duty hereafter for night work.

Along with the survey, results of which are already coming in, a nightly check is now being made of Federal buildings by Ferdinand Kauffholz, chief of the building service division of P. B. A., and his staff to see how widespread night lighting is.

Although some Federal buildings, including the Capitol Hill group and certain others, are not under P. B. A. jurisdiction, voluntary co-operation is expected since Charles A. Peters, building manager of P. B. A., said the deputy air-raid officer for all Federal buildings here. The fund now under discussion at the Budget Bureau would cover them as well as buildings directly under P. B. A. Some of these buildings, however, have their blackout preparations out of their own maintenance funds.

The blackout, Mr. Snyder said, will be achieved in one of two ways: Areas where work must continue will be obscured by necessary construction to permit illumination without light.

Necessary funds for construction will come from regular building maintenance budgets, he said, "after the restoration of these funds will be sought."

\$1,000,000 Needed Here. Now pending in the Budget Bureau is a \$25,000,000 estimate for protection of Federal buildings throughout the country. Part of that estimate is \$1,000,000 for blackout precautions.

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WINDSTORM CAUSES FREAK DAMAGE TO CAR—Russell McCarty (back) and Walter Langley (front) are shown viewing the damage caused when the violent windstorm here yesterday blew a 150-pound plank from the top of an office building being constructed at 1637 K street N.W. and stove in the automobile owned by August Widner, Veterans' Administration attorney.

—Star Staff Photo.

Outside Lights Here Banned During War Except by Permit

Commissioners Order New Regulation to Be Effective March 22

Regulations forbidding any one in the District to burn lights, visible from the outside, unless there are approved arrangements for them to be quickly extinguished were adopted today by the Commissioners on recommendation by Col. Lemuel Bolles, defense director.

Drafted by Corporation Counsel Richmond B. Keck, the rules are effective March 22. They are in line with precautions urged by Commissioner Young, defense co-ordinator, and James M. Landis, national civilian defense director.

Specifically, the regulations prescribe that it shall be unlawful for any person to operate any privately controlled light which may be seen "in the open air" unless:

1. During the time such light is lighted there is present a person responsible for and capable of turning the lights off promptly on notice by defense authorities; or unless

2. The owner, lessee or person in charge of the operation of such light has made adequate arrangements for complying with blackout regulations and has obtained from the captain of the police precinct in which the light is located a certificate that the arrangements are satisfactory.

The new rule will be in effect at all times for the duration of the war.

The Commissioners approved a form to be used by persons seeking certificates for lighting arrangements and the forms will be printed at once. The form will deal with advertising signs, window display lights, warning lights or other forms of lighting which could be spotted by enemy pilots.

Jail and Lorton Ready For Air-Raid Emergencies

The District Jail and Lorton Reformatory are ready for an air raid. The well-developed setup at Lorton is manned in large part by 68 trustees, who have been drilled in air-raid precautions.

E. A. Green, Lorton's assistant general superintendent, said bugle calls are sounded for the first two warnings, while the institution's steam whistle will be blown as the signal of imminent danger. Prisoners will be taken to a nearby ravine, with steep sides, affording good protection from flying debris.

The reformatory is manned by a spotter station 24 hours a day with one prisoner and a guard. A tower for the station is being built on top of one of the institution's buildings.

Mr. Green said he hopes to get four horses for the guards to ride over the reservation as lookouts for paratroops. He pointed out the reformatory is near Fort Belvoir and Quantico.

At the District Jail, Superintendent Thomas Rives said instructions have been issued regarding movement of all prisoners to lower floors and greater safety. The jail, he said, is participating in all blackouts.

Wilson Lauds Nelson For Ban on 'Snacks'

Director Donald M. Nelson of the War, Navy and State Departments today commended Nelson in his agency for mid-morning "snacks."

The compliment came from Representative Wilson, Republican of Indiana, who about a month ago advocated a curfew for Government girl war workers as one means of increasing their efficiency.

"I am glad to see that Mr. Nelson has put his foot down on late breakfasts and conversation on Government time," Representative Wilson declared. "His action confirms what I said some weeks ago. Congratulations to Mr. Nelson."

Citizens Postpone Meeting

The regular meeting of the Piney Branch Citizens' Association, scheduled for 8 o'clock last night at Roosevelt High School, was postponed until the next monthly meeting for lack of a quorum. It was explained that a majority of the members were engaged in civilian defense activities.

Strengthening of U. S. Youth Stressed at Recreation Parley

Health Vital to War Effort, Speaker Says; Eight Welfare Agencies Make Reports

Need for physical strengthening of American youth to put it on a par with that of enemy nations was stressed today by Randolph Myers of the Y. M. C. A. at the third of a series of discussions on recreation sponsored jointly by the Department of Community Centers and Playgrounds and the Council of Social Agencies.

Speaking at the Jewish Community Center, Mr. Myers said the Y. M. C. A. is embarking on a build-up program for boys between the ages of 16 and 20 years. Tests will be given and a regular course prescribed, he said.

Activities Outlined. Mr. Myers was one of eight speakers from various private agencies who outlined recreational activities. The others were Mrs. C. Leslie Glenn of the Girl Scouts, Inc.; Linn C. Drake of the Boy Scouts of America; Mrs. Lawrence Shepherd of the Y. W. C. A.; Miss Dorothy Height of the Phillis Wheatley Y. W. C. A.; Miss Ruth Green of the Jewish Community Center; Mrs. Howard S. Leroy, president of the Federation of Settlements; and Charles Fyfe of the Boys Club of Washington.

Mr. Myers disclosed that the Japanese have just given permission to Y. M. C. A. secretaries of neutral countries to establish contact with United States prisoners of war.

The Girl Scouts, according to Mrs. Glenn, is not just an organization for "ferocious kids" but has the more serious purpose of character building. Recreation agencies, she said, could help the scout program by providing adult leadership and meeting places for troops, and signing duties to senior girls where possible.

Mr. Drake said the Boy Scout program was based on awards for skills and accomplishments and helping youth build its own character. He cited the work of the scouts in the aluminum collection program in the early days of national defense.

There will be a definite camp problem this summer he added because the anxiety of parents to get their children out of the city will increase while the availability of older boys as assistants is diminishing as they now get jobs.

Membership in the Y. W. C. A. is not a prerequisite to the use of its facilities, according to Miss Height, who outlined the work the colored Y. W. C. A. is doing during the war period.

The nursery school problem here was stressed by Mrs. Leroy who said those of the eight settlement houses belonging to the Community Chest are insufficient to meet the demand.

Art Work Discussed. Mrs. Shepherd outlined the work being done in the field of arts at the Y. W. C. A. to develop both skills and appreciation. Physical and special activities also are programmed she added.

Recreation coverage of the Jewish Community Center was described by Miss Green who said the program was not restricted to those of Jewish faith.

Mr. Fyfe said his organization, working with boys in the war period, was trying to do the "same job a lot better."

Charles Cunningham of the council presided and introduced the speakers.

Parents' Views Sought On Opening Schools A Half Hour Later

Van Duzer Feels Plan Would Help Relieve Traffic Congestion

Traffic Director William A. Van Duzer today sought to obtain the reaction of parents of school children to his proposal that schools be opened and closed a half hour later than usual in order to relieve the morning traffic jam.

Mr. Van Duzer has explained that every mass transportation vehicle is needed for the movement of war workers to and from their offices during rush hours and has asked that the schools open at 9:30 a.m. instead of 9 a.m. and close at 3:30 p.m. instead of 3 p.m.

This action would free some 70 buses and streetcars for the use of Federal and other war workers. Mr. Van Duzer stated. His proposal is under consideration by the Board of Education.

The traffic director, seeking to get reactions from parents, has asked that the following coupon be clipped and sent to the public relations section, Department of Vehicles and Traffic, Municipal Center Building:

Traffic Director William A. Van Duzer: I am the parent of () number child(ren) in a public () private () parochial () school. I am () am not () in favor of the 9:30 a.m. opening and 3:30 p.m. closing of schools. My child(ren) do () do not () use the public transportation system to and from classes.

Comment

Plans Lenten Service

The Rev. Wendell S. Tredick will preach at a community lenten service at 8 p.m. tomorrow at the Kensington (Md.) Baptist Church. He is pastor of the Warner Memorial Presbyterian Church in Kensington.

Workman Injured As 50-Mile Wind Whips District Area

Home, Property Damage Reported in Series Of Freak Accidents

One man was injured and considerable damage to private property and homes in the Washington area was reported yesterday as a 50-mile-an-hour wind whipped the District and vicinity.

Charles Mitchell, 43, of 115 Defense highway, Bladensburg, Md., spent last night in Casualty Hospital after treatment for a shoulder injury and nose abrasion. A piece of plaster blown from a building on which he was working at New York and West Virginia avenues N.E., struck him.

In addition to uprooting numerous trees and breaking window panes in private homes, the sudden storm played many freaks. A parked car owned by August Widner, an attorney with the Veterans' Administration, was damaged when a plank weighing 150 pounds was lifted from the top of the 12-story Commonwealth Office Building under construction at 1637 K street N.W. and landed on his car. Three other planks struck the rear courtyard.

Mrs. Job Salloom, 1330 Maryland avenue N.E., looked out her front window to see the wind smash a big tree and topple it against another tree, missing her automobile.

The storm's severity crumpled the heavy canvas canopy at the Pennsylvania entrance to the Willard Hotel.

A light snow fell at 2:10 p.m. At 6 p.m. another trace of snow was reported from Bethesda, Md. As a harbinger of better things to come, Mrs. C. E. Richmond, 9 Shepherd street, Chevy Chase, looked from her doorway and saw a robin.

Harbor police recovered two boats which were lost in the Georgetown Channel, the other in the Anacostia River near the Sousa Bridge.

D. C. Gets \$2,134,350 In First Allocation Under Lanham Act

All but Two Projects Of Seven Are Sited For Anacostia Area

The first District money under the first Lanham Act became formally available to the Commissioners late yesterday when they signed "orders" on seven projects from the Federal Works Agency. The total amount is \$2,134,350.

All but two of the seven projects—some pumps and filters for Dalecarlia Reservoir—are for the Anacostia area, where the mushrooming defense population has been particularly heavy.

Of the total allocation, \$1,562,350 was in grants and \$572,000 in loans. The loans are under approximately the same terms as the outstanding P. W. A. loans to the city, according to D. V. Auld, acting P. W. A. director for the District. Mr. Auld said the interest was 1.335 per cent on the loans, which are to be repaid annually over a 10-year period.

The projects for Anacostia are a 30-inch water main, a 24-inch water main, a storm sewer along South Capitol street to protect Bolling Field and Navy installations, the Patterson Elementary School at Atlantic street and Nichols avenue S.E., and extensions of fire alarms in the area.

Mr. Phillips, in recommending that the Commissioners accept the "offers," pointed out that they were in line with the original application of the city heads, except that the \$57,000 allowance for extending fire alarms represented only half of what was asked. This entire amount, however, is a grant.

The District was given authority by Congress to accept up to \$2,600,000 in funds under the Lanham Act, and any future requests which would push the total above this limit would, in the opinion of District officials, require additional enabling legislation.

Convicted of Tire Theft

WINCHESTER, Va., March 10 (Special). Delbert Light, 39, was under a six-month jail sentence today, having been convicted before Trial Magistrate Largent of stealing an automobile tire.



Picture shows American flag on The Star Building's roof which was torn by the high wind yesterday. The dome of the Capitol is seen in the background. —A. P. Photo.

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Harbor police recovered two boats which were lost in the Georgetown Channel, the other in the Anacostia River near the Sousa Bridge.

Robert Henry Phillips, 77, Trolley Developer, Dies

Robert Henry Phillips, 77, long active in the development of streetcar lines, died here yesterday. Funeral services will be held at 3:30 p.m. tomorrow at the John R. Wright funeral home, 1337 Tenth street N.W., with burial in Glenwood Cemetery.

Mr. Phillips, who made his home at 1737 Pennsylvania street N.W., was born in Georgetown January 21, 1865. He was graduated from Lehigh University in 1887, where he studied engineering. He attended National Law School here and passed the bar examination.

He was active for many years in construction of car lines in Virginia and Maryland and had been interested in recent years in the development of Kensington, Md., where he was a property holder.

Mr. Phillips was survived by his widow, Mrs. Gertrude D. Phillips, and two sisters, Mrs. Sherman E. Burroughs and Mrs. George F. Shafer, both of this city.

District Man Tricked Out of \$678 by Trio

Loss of \$678 by a film-flam trick was reported to police yesterday by James Andrew McKee, 1861 Corcoran street N.E.

Mr. McKee told police he was accosted by three colored men as he left a bank at Seventh and K streets N.W. He accompanied them to Navy court N.W., where a discussion took place involving a large sum of money one of the strangers said he wanted Mr. McKee to keep for him. When the trio left, the victim found the packet he thought contained his funds held nothing of value.

P. U. C. Studies Plea to Issue Gas Stock

Decision Expected at Executive Session This Afternoon

An urgent petition by officials of the Washington Gas Light Co. for "authority" to issue 90,000 shares of \$4.25 preferred stock was taken under advisement today by members of the Public Utilities Commission after company representatives and commission members debated legal and financial issues for two and a half hours.

The commission was scheduled to meet in executive session this afternoon to decide whether to grant or reject the request or lay down a new policy.

The debate became heated at some points. Commission Chairman Gregory Hankin declared arguments of company counsel were "absurd." Commissioner James H. Flanagan suggested the company plan might leave the commission in a "silly position" and E. Barrett Prettyman, company counsel, insisted the concern merely was trying to follow the law and to deal with an urgent practical situation.

Funds Declared Badly Needed.